

HEMANT MISHRA

Sudha Murty, *73*
Author & Philanthropist

A Gentle Storyteller

ACCOMPLISHMENT
A Padma Bhushan recipient in 2023, has touched many lives with her writings and work at Infosys Foundation

DURING A CHAT AT A RECENT event in Bengaluru, N.R. Narayana Murthy—the co-founder and chairman emeritus of Infosys—made a candid admission. That he had hardly spent any time with his children, Akshata and Rohan, when they were young, and the two were brought up by his wife, Sudha, even as she was "a better engineer than I was".

Born in Shiggaon in 1950, Sudha Murty was the first woman engineer hired by TELCO, now known as Tata Motors, in Pune in 1974. It was while pursuing her master's in computer science at the Indian Institute of Science in Bengaluru that she came across the company's advertisement calling for engineers, but specifying that 'lady students need not apply'. Upset, she shot off a postcard to J.R.D. Tata, and soon got an interview call.

WORK ETHIC

"For me, every day is a working day and every day is a holiday. Because I enjoy my work"

SWEARS BY...
Her grandmother's message that 'for learning, age is no bar'

The stint as an engineer was only a part of Murty's long list of accomplishments. She established the Infosys Foundation in 1996—it was a question from Akshata, about her goals in life, that seeded the idea—and served as chairperson for 25 years, working towards financial and social empowerment of women, especially among devadasis. Other social projects included building libraries, constructing toilets and supporting relief work during as many as 16 natural disasters. "I feel very proud of the kind of work we did at Infosys Foundation...in all the disasters, the last one Covid," she said in 2022 while commemorating the software giant's four decades. What inspires her? "When I look at the poor, I always feel it is my duty to do something for them. And that is the reason I work extremely hard."

Murty has been just as prolific as a bestselling author—both in Kannada and English—with 248 titles spanning genres such as children's books, short stories, novels and travelogues. A voracious reader herself, she reads at least 100 pages a day, and enjoys learning new things. At age 60, Murty even enrolled in a diploma course in Indology. "Because my grandmother told me that for learning, age is no bar," she explains. "The day you stop learning, you become old." ■

–Ajay Sukumaran